

CEO of the SEA

The Syrian Electronic Army not the great blue oceans. Turns out the leader of the infamous hacking unit is a 19 year old!

How long can a severed head live?

Possibly one the most morbid experiments ever. Still, it puts to rest centuries-old tales of severed heads blinking and even attempting to speak: <http://dgit.in/1ak4Xrj>

man. Groupon India recently offered a deal on onions at a discounted price of ₹9 per kg, an offer that was part of its daily deals. The price was so attractive it that led to a flood of traffic to the website, causing it to overload the company's servers and crashing the site. Groupon sold about 3,000 kilograms of onions, in just 44 minutes. More than 8,000 kilograms were bought by over 17,065 users.

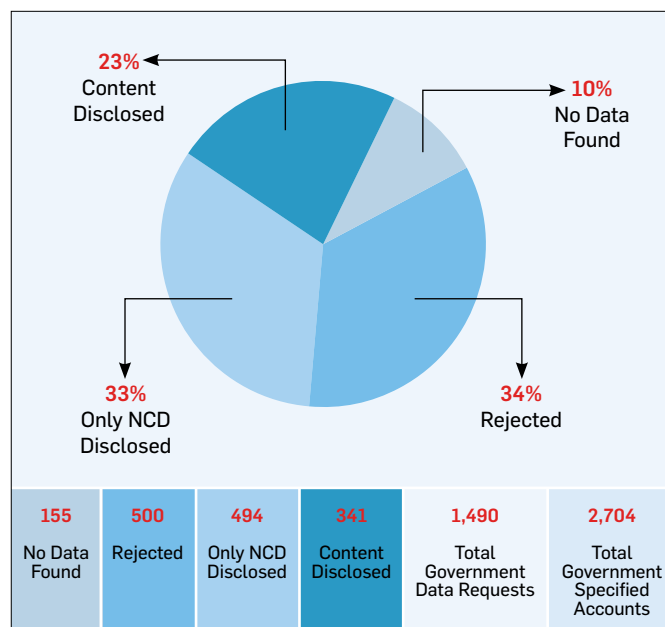
Onion prices have more than tripled in the past few months in India, selling at a price as high as ₹100/kg for some time recently. The depreciating rupee value has made matters worse and India has run into food supply shortages, resulting in dramatically inflated food costs.

Groupon advertised the deal in a tongue-in-cheek manner, with Ankur Warikoo, Groupon India CEO stating that the company wanted to sell the onions at a price that most of the users have completely forgotten about.

It was the first time ever the company had put onions on sale and the response, Warikoo said, was "overwhelming". He added, "This kind of onion price was last seen in 1999. The first day itself we ended up selling 5,000 kilos. Today [Friday] our site crashed completely for 10 minutes. It's been absolutely fantastic."

Yahoo: Indian govt. has made almost 1,500 requests for user information in 2013

Yahoo has published its first-ever transparency report, which reveals the number of requests made by the governments across the world for accessing users' information. The report, covering the first six months of 2013, shows that Yahoo received a maximum of 12,444 requests



Government data requests

from the U.S. government. Germany followed with 4,295 requests. India is also in the list with 1,490 data requests.

Yahoo says it provided information including communications in Yahoo Mail or Messenger, photos on Flickr and Yahoo Address Book entries. The company also acknowledged sharing non-content related information, including a person's name, location or Internet Protocol address. In case of India, Yahoo ceded 341 government data requests resulting in disclosure of some user data.

"At Yahoo, we take user privacy seriously and appreciate our role as a global company in promoting freedom of expression wherever we do business. That's why we're issuing our first global transparency report, which details government data requests from January 1 through June 30. We include national security requests within the scope of our aggregate statistics," said Yahoo in a statement. The data, however, does not

include requests for data on Tumblr, which the company took over recently. Yahoo announced that Tumblr would issue a separate transparency report at a later date, and would issue its own additional reports on an ongoing basis.

Yahoo's latest report is part of the ongoing campaign by internet companies to promote transparency on the web. In the past, Microsoft, Google and Twitter have issued similar reports. Facebook recently released its first report on requests made by the global governments to access users' information.

Covering the first six months of 2013, ending June 30, Facebook's 'Global Governments Requests Report' revealed that the U.S. had made the highest number of requests (over 11,000) for information about users. India ranks second with 3,245 requests for information in the first six months.

The transparency report also comes in the wake of the recent revelations of data mining by the U.S. government.

While the US government has faced criticism for its controversial PRISM program, the Indian government is also drawing flak for its efforts to pre-screen internet content.

In early August, Twitter revealed in its transparency report that India had sought to withhold a total of three tweets, of which one request was made by the government, and the others came from a court order.

With Edward Snowden's crusade against the NSA and the existence of PRISM, the agency's data collection and analytics program, going public, more and more users are pressuring companies to be forthright about their exchanges with governments around the world especially when it comes to information requests. As a result, we've seen more focus being put on transparency reports being released by companies such as Twitter, Facebook and Google.

When the privacy debated so much in public forums lately, the importance of these transparency reports cannot be underestimated. While speaking on the matter to VentureBeat, Electronic Frontier Foundation staff attorney Nate Cardozo said, "The benefit is pretty significant...with transparency comes accountability. The first step in any real democratic process requires that transparency." However, the U.S. government (at least) is fighting back against these companies in an effort to reduce the amount of information being revealed in these transparency reports. Companies such as LinkedIn, Google and Yahoo and possibly others have already initiated court proceedings against the gag orders issued by the U.S. government, which limit the information released to the public in the transparency reports. 